
5. Get larger cuts

Get comfortable working with some of the larger meat items that go on sale regularly, such as picnic pork roasts, giant legs of ham or lamb, and the long center-cut pork loins.

The pork loins can be cut into smaller roasts, or sliced into lean boneless pork medallions to serve with a spicy peanut sauce or a fruit compote. As for some of the others, the simplest way I've found to go is tossing them into an electric roaster on the counter and tossing some basmati into the rice cooker. Throw together a quick Asian coleslaw for a side dish, and you've got a low-stress meal that provides loads of meat and rice leftovers for the freezer. (Think fried rice, casseroles, and soups galore.) Found a great deal on boneless leg of lamb? Hack it up for grilled meat and veggie kabobs, or make friends with the butcher and have it ground up as a replacement for hamburger.

6. Stockpile during seasonal sales

This does require freezer space, but can easily save 50% or more off your total meat bill. Combine this strategy with other ideas in this article, and

you'll be living large while saving big. Look out for hot dogs during summer picnic season, turkeys during the winter holidays, and hams throughout various times of the year.

7. Shaved, not sliced

For those who want deli meat and nothing else, you can get more mileage from your meat money this way. If you buy meat from the counter regularly, just ask them to shave your meat for you rather than slice it. Hard-core savers can get a slicer and try it at home if they want, but busy folks who are just looking for some minor tweaks in their meat budget can do this with no extra stress, time, or up-front cost. Beef up your sandwiches with banana peppers, bargain bacon, hummus, and other goodies. Or splurge on a chef's salad since your pennies have been pinched ahead of time. Oven-toasted subs are a great way to go with this as well, as the minor roasting time releases more of the fats and flavor. You'll be using less meat, and won't even really notice that much. I promise.

8. Buy a side

A side of beef or lamb, that is. Again, this will require some freezer space.